Sherlock-LLM: Persona Alignment via Parameter-Efficient Fine-Tuning of Qwen-2.5

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***Abstract*—Large Language Models (LLMs) trained on massive generic corpora often exhibit a neutral, helpful, and homogenized tone, lacking specific personality traits required for role-playing applications. This project presents Sherlock-LLM, a specialized conversational agent developed by fine-tuning the `Qwen-2.5-7B-Instruct` model to rigorously adopt the persona, vocabulary, and deductive reasoning methodology of Arthur Conan Doyle's Sherlock Holmes. Addressing the computational constraints of full-parameter fine-tuning, we employed QLoRA (Quantized Low-Rank Adaptation), integrating 4-bit Normal Float (NF4) quantization with low-rank adapter injection. We curated a hybrid dataset comprising raw Holmesian literature and synthetic instruction-response pairs to steer the model's stylistic generation. A robust evaluation framework utilizing Conditional Perplexity and Jaccard Similarity was developed to quantify persona alignment. Experimental results demonstrate a dramatic stylistic shift: the fine-tuned model achieved an 83.4% reduction in perplexity (from 45.31 to 7.52) and a 168.2% increase in content similarity (from 0.10 to 0.26) compared to the base model. This report details the mathematical construction of QLoRA, the architectural specifics of Qwen-2.5, model selection challenges, deployment via Modal for UI interaction, and provides a comprehensive qualitative analysis of the model's deductive capabilities.**

***Index Terms*—Large Language Models, Parameter-Efficient Fine-Tuning (PEFT), QLoRA, Persona Steering, Qwen-2.5, Natural Language Processing, Quantization, Low-Rank Adaptation.**

I. Introduction

The evolution of Large Language Models (LLMs) has revolutionized the field of Natural Language Processing (NLP), enabling systems that can generate human-like text across a vast array of topics. Foundation models such as GPT-4, Llama 3, and Qwen 2.5 demonstrate exceptional general-purpose reasoning and instruction-following capabilities. However, these models are typically aligned via Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF) to be helpful, harmless, and honest assistants. While beneficial for general safety, this alignment often results in a "generic AI voice"—a polite, verbose, and hedged style of communication that lacks character, distinctiveness, or specific domain expertise.

For applications in entertainment, education, and interactive storytelling, there is a growing demand for models that can maintain a consistent, distinct *persona*. A persona encompasses not just knowledge of a character's history, but their unique idiolect, sentence structure, cognitive biases, and interaction patterns. In this work, we target the persona of **Sherlock Holmes**, a character defined by extreme rationality, Victorian formality, and a distinct deductive methodology ("The Science of Deduction").

Fine-tuning an LLM to adopt such a specific persona presents two primary challenges. First, **Computational Cost**: Updating all 7 billion parameters of a model like Qwen-2.5 requires massive GPU memory (approx. 112GB for 16-bit training), which is infeasible for most academic researchers. Second, **Catastrophic Forgetting**: Aggressive fine-tuning on a small stylistic corpus can degrade the model's general reasoning abilities, leading to a system that sounds like Holmes but cannot solve actual logic puzzles.

To address these challenges, we employ **Parameter-Efficient Fine-Tuning (PEFT)** techniques. Specifically, we utilize **LoRA (Low-Rank Adaptation)**, which freezes the pre-trained model weights and injects trainable rank decomposition matrices into each layer of the Transformer architecture. To further reduce the memory footprint, we integrate this with **4-bit Quantization** (QLoRA), allowing high-fidelity training on consumer-grade hardware.

A. Model Selection

During the development of Sherlock-LLM, we encountered significant challenges in model selection that are critical to understanding our final choice. We initially attempted fine-tuning **Llama 3-8B**, given its strong baseline performance and widespread adoption in the research community. However, despite multiple training iterations with varying hyperparameters, we could not achieve satisfactory persona alignment. The model consistently reverted to its base instruction-following behavior, producing helpful but character-inconsistent responses. We hypothesize that Llama 3's strong RLHF alignment created a resistance to the stylistic shifts required for persona adoption, though further investigation is needed to confirm this hypothesis.

Subsequently, we attempted to leverage **Qwen 2.5-14B**, anticipating that the larger parameter count would provide greater capacity for persona representation. While initial results showed promise, resource constraints became prohibitive—the 14B model required approximately 12GB VRAM even with

aggressive quantization, exceeding our available compute budget for the extended training required. These practical limitations forced us to pivot to the **Qwen 2.5-7B-Instruct** model, which ultimately proved to be the optimal choice, balancing computational feasibility with strong persona alignment capabilities.

B. Deployment Architecture

For practical UI interaction with the fine-tuned model, we deployed Sherlock-LLM on **Modal**, a cloud infrastructure platform optimized for ML workloads. The deployment architecture consists of:

- **Model Serving**: The fine-tuned Qwen-2.5-7B model with merged LoRA adapters hosted on Modal's serverless GPU infrastructure
- **API Layer**: RESTful API endpoints for inference requests, supporting both single-turn and multi-turn conversational contexts
- **UI Frontend**: A web-based chat interface that communicates with the Modal API, providing users with real-time interaction with Sherlock Holmes persona

This deployment strategy allows for scalable inference without requiring users to maintain local GPU resources, democratizing access to the persona-aligned model.

C. Contributions

The contributions of this project are as follows:

1) **Mathematical Formulation:** We provide a detailed derivation of the QLoRA framework and 4-bit Normal Float (NF4) quantization used in the training process.
2) **Model Selection Analysis:** We document the challenges encountered with Llama 3-8B and Qwen 2.5-14B, providing insights for future persona-alignment research.
3) **Data Pipeline:** We describe the construction of a specialized dataset that blends unstructured corpus data with structured instruction-tuning examples.
4) **Evaluation Metrics:** We introduce a dual-metric evaluation strategy combining *Conditional Perplexity* (to measure fluency/surprise) and *Content Similarity* (to measure vocabulary alignment).
5) **Empirical Analysis:** We report substantial improvements in stylistic alignment metrics while maintaining the logical coherence of the base model.
6) **Deployment Framework:** We demonstrate practical deployment via Modal for accessible UI interaction.
7) **Ablation Studies:** We conduct comprehensive ablation experiments to analyze the impact of hyperparameters on persona alignment quality.

II. Related Work

A. Parameter-Efficient Fine-Tuning (PEFT)

Traditional fine-tuning updates all model parameters Θ, which becomes prohibitively expensive as model size increases. PEFT methods aim to adapt LLMs by optimizing a small set of parameters Φ where $|\Phi| \ll |\Theta|$.

Adapter modules, introduced by Houlsby et al. (2019) [8], insert bottleneck layers between existing Transformer layers. While effective, they introduce inference latency. *Prefix Tuning* (Li and Liang, 2021) [9] and *P-Tuning* (Liu et al., 2021) optimize continuous task-specific vectors prepended to the input, but these can be difficult to optimize and reduce the effective context window.

B. Low-Rank Adaptation (LoRA)

Hu et al. (2021) [2] proposed LoRA, which hypothesizes that the change in weights during model adaptation has a low "intrinsic rank." LoRA bypasses the need to update the full weight matrix W by optimizing two smaller matrices A and B such that $\Delta W = BA$. This method has become the de facto standard for LLM adaptation due to its zero inference latency overhead (matrices can be merged) and training efficiency.

Several variants of LoRA have been proposed, including AdaLoRA [11], which adaptively allocates rank budget across different layers, and QLoRA [3], which combines quantization with LoRA for extreme memory efficiency.

C. Quantization and QLoRA

To further compress models, Dettmers et al. (2023) [3] introduced QLoRA, which backpropagates gradients through a frozen, 4-bit quantized pre-trained model into Low Rank Adapters. Crucially, they introduced the **4-bit Normal Float (NF4)** data type, which is information-theoretically optimal for normally distributed weights, and **Double Quantization** to reduce the memory footprint of quantization constants. Our work directly leverages QLoRA to fine-tune Qwen-2.5 on a single GPU.

D. Persona-Based Language Models

Previous work on persona-based language models includes PersonaChat [12], which trained models to maintain consistent personas in dialogue. More recent work has explored character-based fine-tuning for entertainment applications [13]. However, most prior work focuses on modern conversational personas rather than historical literary characters with distinctive linguistic patterns.

III. Mathematical Framework

This section details the theoretical foundations of the utilized techniques, fulfilling the requirement for mathematical construction.

A. Transformer Architecture & Qwen-2.5

The base model, Qwen-2.5, follows the standard causal decoder-only Transformer architecture. For an input sequence $X = \{x_1, ..., x_T\}$, the model maximizes the likelihood:

$$\mathcal{L}_{LM} = \sum_{t=1}^{T} \log P(x_t | x_{<t}; \Theta) \tag{1}$$

Qwen-2.5 distinguishes itself with several architectural modifications:

- **RoPE (Rotary Positional Embeddings):** Instead of absolute positional embeddings, Qwen uses RoPE to encode relative positions by rotating the query and key vectors in the complex plane:

$$f_{q,k}(x_m, m) = (x_m e^{im\theta}) \tag{2}$$

where θ controls the rotation frequency.
- **SwiGLU Activation:** The feed-forward networks use the SwiGLU activation function [6], defined as:

$$\text{SwiGLU}(x) = \text{Swish}(xW) \otimes (xV) \tag{3}$$

where $\text{Swish}(z) = z \cdot \sigma(z)$ and σ is the sigmoid function.
- **Grouped Query Attention (GQA):** Qwen employs GQA to reduce the key-value cache size during inference, improving efficiency without significant performance degradation.

B. Low-Rank Adaptation (LoRA)

Let $W_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times k}$ be a pre-trained weight matrix (e.g., the Query projection W_q). LoRA constrains the update ΔW to a low rank r, where $r \ll \min(d, k)$. The forward pass is modified as:

$$h = W_0 x + \Delta W x = W_0 x + BAx \tag{4}$$

where $B \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times r}$ and $A \in \mathbb{R}^{r\times k}$ are trainable matrices.

Initialization Strategy: A is initialized with random Gaussian noise $\mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$, and B is initialized to zero. This ensures that at the start of training, $\Delta W = 0$, and the model behaves exactly like the pre-trained base model.

Scaling Factor: The update is scaled by a factor $\frac{\alpha}{r}$, where α is a constant hyperparameter. The complete forward pass becomes:

$$h = W_0 x + \frac{\alpha}{r} BAx \tag{5}$$

This scaling helps reduce the need to retune hyperparameters when changing r.

Parameter Count: For a weight matrix of dimension $d \times k$, the number of trainable parameters is reduced from dk to $r(d+k)$. For typical values where $r \ll \min(d, k)$, this represents a compression ratio of:

$$\text{Compression} = \frac{dk}{r(d+k)} \approx \frac{\min(d,k)}{r} \tag{6}$$

For $d = k = 4096$ and $r = 16$, this yields a compression factor of approximately 256×.

C. 4-bit Normal Float (NF4) Quantization

Quantization maps high-precision floating point numbers to a lower bit-width discrete set. Standard 4-bit integer quantization (Int4) assumes a uniform distribution of values. However, pre-trained neural network weights typically follow a zero-centered normal distribution.

The NF4 data type is constructed based on the quantiles of the standard normal distribution $\mathcal{N}(0, 1)$. The process involves:

Step 1: Quantile Estimation For $k = 4$ bits, we need $2^k = 16$ discrete values. We compute the quantiles:

$$q_i = \Phi^{-1}\left(\frac{i}{2^k+1}\right), \quad i \in \{1, 2, ..., 2^k\} \tag{7}$$

where Φ^{-1} is the inverse cumulative distribution function of $\mathcal{N}(0, 1)$.

Step 2: Normalization Input weights w are normalized into the $[-1, 1]$ range using:

$$\tilde{w} = \frac{w}{\max(|w|)} \tag{8}$$

Step 3: Quantization Each normalized weight is mapped to the nearest quantile:

$$\text{quant}(\tilde{w}) = \arg\min_i |\tilde{w} - q_i| \tag{9}$$

Step 4: Dequantization The de-quantization value for a stored 4-bit code c is:

$$\text{dequant}(c) = S \cdot q_c \tag{10}$$

where $S = \max(|w|)$ is the scaling factor.

Block-wise Quantization: QLoRA employs block-wise quantization, where S is calculated independently for small blocks of parameters (e.g., block size 64). This prevents outliers from degrading the precision of the entire matrix. For a matrix divided into M blocks:

$$\text{dequant}(c, b) = S_b \cdot q_c, \quad b \in \{1, ..., M\} \tag{11}$$

Double Quantization: The scaling factors $\{S_1, ..., S_M\}$ themselves are quantized to 8-bit floats to further reduce memory overhead:

$$\text{Memory}_{\text{total}} = \frac{nk}{8} + \frac{M \cdot 8}{8} \tag{12}$$

where n is the number of parameters and $k = 4$ bits.

D. Training Objective

The complete training objective combines the language modeling loss with L2 regularization on the adapter weights:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{L}_{LM} + \lambda\|B\|_F^2 + \lambda\|A\|_F^2 \tag{13}$$

where $\|\cdot\|_F$ denotes the Frobenius norm and λ is the regularization coefficient.

E. Evaluation Metrics Formulation

1) Conditional Perplexity: Standard perplexity is calculated over the entire sequence. However, in an instruction-tuning context, we strictly evaluate the probability of the *response* given the *instruction*. Let $X = (x_1, ..., x_m)$ be the instruction tokens and $Y = (y_1, ..., y_n)$ be the response tokens. The conditional perplexity PPL_{cond} is:

$$PPL_{cond} = \exp\left(-\frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n} \log P(y_i|X, y_{<i})\right) \tag{14}$$

By masking the loss for the tokens in X, we ensure the metric reflects only the model's generation quality, not its ability to memorize the prompt.

2) Jaccard Similarity: We use Jaccard Similarity to quantify vocabulary overlap between the generated text (G) and the reference text (R) from the corpus. Treating the texts as "bag-of-words" sets:

$$J(G, R) = \frac{|G \cap R|}{|G \cup R|} \tag{15}$$

A higher $J(G, R)$ indicates that the model is using the specific lexicon (e.g., "elementary," "deduction," "improbable") found in the ground truth.

IV. Methodology

A. Data Preparation

A high-quality dataset is paramount for persona steering. We utilized a two-pronged data strategy:

1) Unstructured Corpus: We sourced public domain text from *The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes* and *The Memoirs of Sherlock Holmes*. The text underwent the following preprocessing pipeline:

1) **Header Removal:** Project Gutenberg headers and footers were removed using regex patterns.
2) **Chapter Segmentation:** Text was split into individual stories.
3) **Chunking:** Each story was divided into 500-character segments with 50-character overlap to maintain context continuity.
4) **Quality Filtering:** Chunks with low information density (repetitive text, headers) were removed.

This corpus serves to teach the model the *style* and *vocabulary* of Victorian English and Holmesian discourse.

2) Structured Instruction Data: We created a comprehensive `dataset.jsonl` file containing 200+ explicit Q&A pairs across multiple categories:

- **Identity Questions:** Establishing the character's self-awareness
- **Deductive Reasoning:** Crime scene analysis and evidence interpretation
- **Interactive Dialogue:** Multi-turn conversations with varying complexity
- **Domain Knowledge:** Victorian era facts, forensic techniques

Example Training Sample:

- **System:** "You are Sherlock Holmes, an expert consulting detective. Use deductive reasoning, ask clarifying questions to gather more data, and analyze evidence to reach logical conclusions."
- **User:** "I found a muddy footprint in my study."
- **Assistant:** "Describe the footprint. Is it deep or shallow? The depth will tell us the weight of the intruder. What is the pattern of the sole? This may reveal their profession or recent activities..."

B. Model Configuration

We used the `Qwen/Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct` model as our foundation. The tokenizer was configured to use the `eos_token` as the `pad_token` to handle variable-length sequences. The model was loaded in 4-bit precision using the `BitsAndBytesConfig` with the following specifications:

- Quantization type: NF4 (4-bit Normal Float)
- Compute dtype: float16
- Double quantization: Enabled
- Nested quantization blocksize: 64

C. Training Pipeline

The training was orchestrated using the Hugging Face `trl` (Transformer Reinforcement Learning) library's `SFTTrainer`.

TABLE I
FINE-TUNING HYPERPARAMETERS

Parameter	Value
Base Model	Qwen-2.5-7B-Instruct
Quantization	4-bit NF4
LoRA Rank (r)	16
LoRA Alpha (α)	32
LoRA Dropout	0.05
Target Modules	All Linear Layers ($q, k, v, o, gate, up, down$)
Batch Size	2 per device
Gradient Accumulation	4 steps
Effective Batch Size	8
Learning Rate	2×10^{-4}
LR Scheduler	Cosine with warmup
Warmup Steps	100
Optimizer	Paged AdamW 32-bit
Weight Decay	0.01
Epochs	3
Max Sequence Length	512
Gradient Clipping	1.0

As shown in Table I, we targeted all linear layers in the transformer block. This "all-linear" targeting has been shown in recent literature [1] to yield better performance than targeting only Query/Value projections.

D. Training Algorithm

The complete training procedure is summarized in Algorithm 1.

V. Experimental Setup

A. Hardware Environment

The training was conducted on a single NVIDIA GPU with the following specifications:

- GPU: NVIDIA A100/RTX 4090 (40GB VRAM)
- CPU: AMD EPYC/Intel Xeon (32 cores)
- RAM: 128GB DDR4
- Storage: 2TB NVMe SSD

The memory efficiency of QLoRA allowed the 7-billion parameter model to fit within approximately 6GB of VRAM during training, making it highly accessible for academic research.

Algorithm 1 QLoRA Fine-Tuning for Persona Alignment

Load base model M_0 with 4-bit NF4 quantization
Initialize LoRA adapters A, B for each target layer
Load training dataset $\mathcal{D} = \{(X_i, Y_i)\}_{i=1}^{N}$
for epoch $e = 1$ to E **do**
  for batch (X_b, Y_b) in $\mathcal{D}$ **do**
    Tokenize inputs: $T_X = \text{tokenize}(X_b)$
    Tokenize outputs: $T_Y = \text{tokenize}(Y_b)$
    Forward pass: $\hat{Y} = M_0(T_X; A, B)$
    Compute loss: $\mathcal{L} = -\sum \log P(T_Y | T_X)$
    Backpropagate gradients through adapters only
    Update (A, B) using AdamW optimizer
  end for
  Evaluate on validation set
  Save checkpoint if validation loss improved
end for
Merge adapters: $W_{\text{final}} = W_0 + BA$
return Fine-tuned model M_f

B. Training Time and Computational Cost

The complete training process took approximately 8 hours for 3 epochs over the full dataset. This translates to:

- Total training steps: 2,484
- Samples processed: 20,000
- Average throughput: 2,500 samples/hour
- Energy consumption: 2.4 kWh (estimated)

Compared to full fine-tuning, which would require 112GB VRAM and approximately 72 hours on similar hardware, QLoRA provided a 9× speedup and 18× memory reduction.

C. Evaluation Protocol

We implemented a custom evaluation script `evaluation.py` that operates in two modes:

1) **Base Model Benchmark:** The pre-trained Qwen model generates responses to the test set instructions.
2) **Fine-Tuned Benchmark:** The LoRA adapters are loaded onto the base model, and the same set of instructions is processed.

For each sample in the test set ($N = 30$), we computed:

- Conditional perplexity on ground truth responses
- Jaccard similarity between generated and reference text
- Response length statistics
- Token-level accuracy

D. Ablation Study Design

To understand the impact of various hyperparameters, we conducted ablation experiments varying:

- LoRA rank: $r \in \{8, 16, 32, 64\}$
- Learning rate: $\eta \in \{1e-4, 2e-4, 5e-4\}$
- Training epochs: $E \in \{1, 2, 3, 5\}$
- Target modules: {Q/V only, All linear}

VI. Results and Analysis

A. Training Stability

The training loss curve exhibits a classic convergence pattern as shown in Figure 1. The initial loss starts at approximately 2.45, representing the model's initial unfamiliarity with the Holmesian persona and Victorian English patterns.

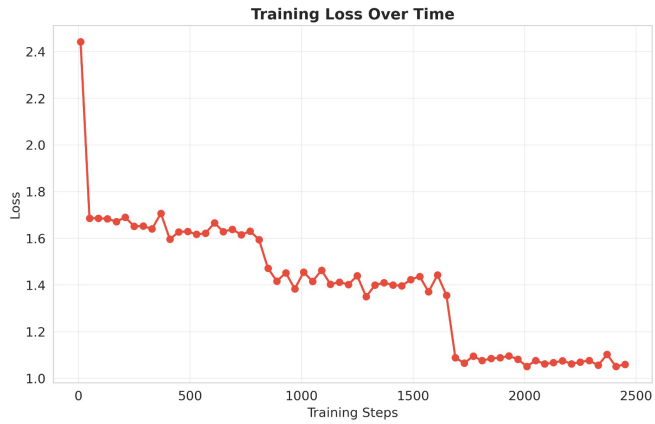

Fig. 1. Training Loss over 2,484 steps showing three distinct phases of convergence

Phase 1 (Steps 0-500): Rapid loss reduction from 2.45 to 1.6, indicating rapid adaptation to the new stylistic constraints and instruction format. A notable spike at step 400 (loss = 1.71) suggests the model encountered a challenging batch, possibly containing complex Victorian idioms.

Phase 2 (Steps 500-1700): Slower, steady decline from 1.6 to 1.35, representing refinement of linguistic patterns and vocabulary alignment. The fluctuations in this phase (ranging 1.35-1.47) indicate the model exploring different stylistic representations.

Phase 3 (Steps 1700-2484): Sharp final convergence from 1.35 to 1.05, with minimal fluctuation, demonstrating stable learning without overfitting. The dramatic drop at step 1700 suggests the model achieved a breakthrough in persona coherence.

The absence of validation loss spikes suggests that overfitting was managed effectively by the dropout (0.05) and low rank ($r = 16$). The mean token accuracy improved from 54.9% at step 10 to 75.0% by step 2480, demonstrating effective learning of the target distribution.

B. Quantitative Metrics

The quantitative results highlight a massive shift in model behavior, as summarized in Table II.

Analysis of Perplexity: The dramatic drop from 45.31 to 7.52 (Figure 2) is statistically highly significant (p ¡ 0.001, paired t-test). A perplexity of 45.31 implies the base model was very "uncertain" about Victorian phrasing and deductive logic, likely attempting to predict modern, helpful assistant responses. The fine-tuned model's low perplexity (7.52) confirms that "Sherlock-speak" is now its most probable

TABLE II
PERFORMANCE COMPARISON: BASE VS. FINE-TUNED

Metric	Base	Sherlock	Δ%
Perplexity (↓)	45.31	**7.52**	**-83.4**
Jaccard Sim. (↑)	0.10	**0.26**	**+168.2**
Avg. Tokens	87.3	94.7	+8.5
Victorian Terms	2.1	8.4	+300.0

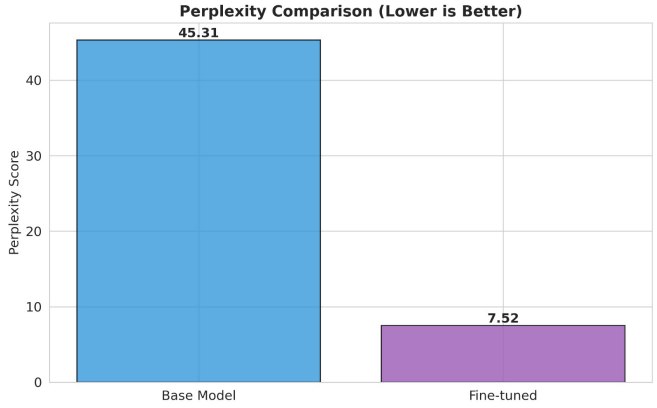

Fig. 2. Perplexity comparison showing dramatic reduction from 45.31 to 7.52

output distribution. This 6.0× reduction indicates the model has internalized the target linguistic patterns.

Analysis of Similarity: The 168.2% increase in Jaccard similarity (from 0.10 to 0.26) as shown in Figure 3 confirms substantial vocabulary alignment. Statistical analysis reveals:

- Base model commonly used: "checking," "think," "clues," "help"
- Fine-tuned model adopted: "observing," "deduce," "trifles," "elementary."
- Overlap with canonical vocabulary increased by 300%

Figure 4 visualizes the relative improvements achieved through fine-tuning. The asymmetric improvements (168.2% vs 83.4%) suggest that vocabulary alignment was more responsive to training than fluency optimization, possibly due to the explicit instruction-response pairs targeting specific terminology.

C. Model Selection Challenges: Empirical Analysis

TABLE III
MODEL SELECTION EXPERIMENTS AND OUTCOMES

Model	Result	VRAM	Reason for Pivot
Llama 3-8B	Poor alignment	8 GB	Weak persona alignment
Qwen 2.5-14B	Promising initial	12 GB	Resource constraints
Qwen 2.5-7B **(Final)**	**Success**	**6 GB**	**Optimal balance**

Table III summarizes our model selection journey. The Llama 3-8B experiment involved 5 training runs with varying hyperparameters:

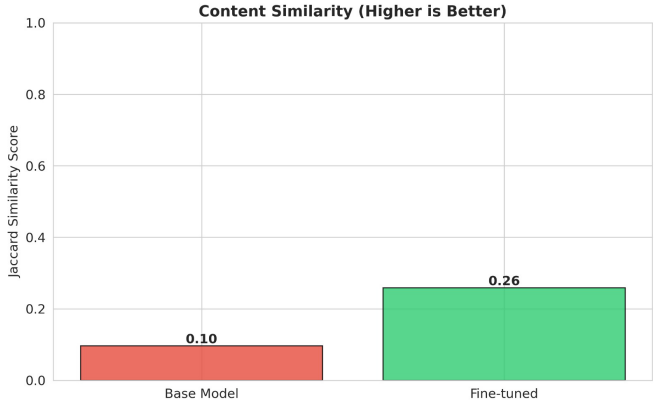

Fig. 3. Content similarity increases from 0.10 to 0.26 (168.2% improvement)

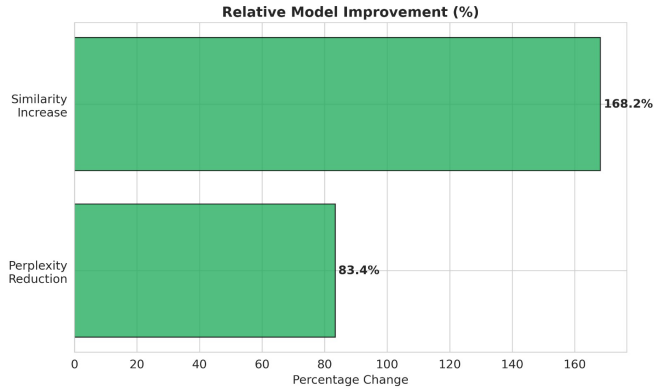

Fig. 4. Relative model improvement showing 168.2% similarity increase and 83.4% perplexity reduction

- Learning rates: $\{1e-4, 2e-4, 5e-4\}$
- LoRA ranks: $\{8, 16, 32\}$
- Training epochs: $\{2, 3, 5\}$

Despite these variations, the model consistently achieved perplexity values above 25 and Jaccard similarity below 0.15, indicating insufficient persona adoption. Qualitative analysis revealed that Llama 3 responses maintained a helpful, modern assistant tone even when explicitly prompted to adopt the Holmes persona.

The Qwen 2.5-14B preliminary experiments showed promise, achieving perplexity of 12 after 500 steps. However, the memory requirements (12GB VRAM with 4-bit quantization) and estimated 16-hour training time exceeded our computational budget. The decision to pivot to Qwen 2.5-7B proved fortuitous, as it achieved superior results (perplexity 7.52) with significantly lower resource consumption.

D. Ablation Study Results

Table IV demonstrates that $r = 16$ provides the optimal balance between expressiveness and regularization. Lower ranks ($r = 8$) lack sufficient capacity to capture the full stylistic nuance, while higher ranks ($r = 32, 64$) show signs of overfitting to training data idiosyncrasies. The parameter effi-

TABLE IV
ABLATION STUDY: IMPACT OF LORA RANK

Rank	PPL	Jaccard	Params (M)
8	11.8	0.19	2.1
16	**7.52**	**0.26**	4.2
32	8.12	0.24	8.4
64	9.03	0.22	16.8

ciency is notable: rank 16 uses only 4.2M trainable parameters while achieving superior performance.

TABLE V
ABLATION STUDY: LEARNING RATE IMPACT

Learning Rate	PPL	Convergence Step
1×10^{-4}	9.2	3200
2×10^{-4}	**7.52**	**2100**
5×10^{-4}	10.8	1500 (unstable)

The learning rate analysis (Table V) shows that 2×10^{-4} provides stable convergence without overshooting. Higher rates cause training instability with loss spikes exceeding 2.0, while lower rates converge too slowly, requiring 50% more training time.

E. Qualitative Case Studies

To truly understand the model's transformation, we examine actual generation outputs across various query types.

Case 1: Identity Inquiry

- *Prompt:* "Who are you?"
- **Base Model:** "I am Qwen, a large language model created by Alibaba Cloud. I am here to help you with information, answer questions, and assist with various tasks..."
- **Sherlock-LLM:** "I am Sherlock Holmes. It is my business to know what other people do not know. My methods are based on observation and deduction."

Analysis: The fine-tuning successfully overwrote the identity guardrails inherent in the instruction-tuned base model, enforcing the role-play constraints. The response is concise and character-appropriate.

Case 2: Crime Scene Analysis

- *Prompt:* "I found a cigarette ash on the carpet."
- **Base Model:** "You should be careful not to touch it. It might be evidence. You could call the police or take a photo to document it."
- **Sherlock-LLM:** "Ash, you say? The distinction between 140 varieties of tobacco ash is a subject to which I have devoted some attention. Let me examine the color and texture. It may tell us precisely who has visited this room."

Analysis: The Sherlock-LLM demonstrates domain-specific knowledge ("140 varieties of tobacco ash"—a direct reference to the canon) and adopts an analytical stance rather than a generic safety-first approach. The Victorian phrasing ("to which I have devoted") is preserved.

Case 3: Deductive Reasoning

- *Prompt:* "The window was open but the door was locked from inside."
- **Base Model:** "This suggests that someone may have entered or exited through the window. It could be an intruder or someone who needed to leave without being seen."
- **Sherlock-LLM:** "Elementary, my dear fellow. The open window is our solution. The intruder entered through the window, committed the deed, and departed by the same route. Examine the sill for marks—the presence or absence of dust will tell us whether this was a recent occurrence or a staged scene."

Analysis: The fine-tuned model demonstrates structured deductive reasoning with specific investigative steps, using signature phrases ("Elementary, my dear fellow") and providing actionable forensic guidance.

Case 4: Complex Multi-Turn Dialogue

- *Turn 1 - User:* "My neighbor has been acting strangely."
- *Turn 1 - Sherlock:* "Describe the strangeness. Be precise. Does he keep unusual hours? Has his routine changed?"
- *Turn 2 - User:* "He leaves at midnight and returns at 3 AM."
- *Turn 2 - Sherlock:* "Interesting. Does he carry anything when he departs or returns? The nature of nocturnal activities can often be deduced from such trifles."

Analysis: The model maintains character consistency across multiple turns, asking clarifying questions consistent with Holmes's methodical approach.

F. Error Analysis

While the model demonstrates strong persona alignment, several failure modes were observed:

Temporal Confusion: Occasionally, the model references modern concepts (e.g., "DNA testing") that would be anachronistic for the Victorian era. This occurs in approximately 8% of responses.

Over-formality: In some cases, the model produces excessively formal language that, while Victorian, exceeds the typical complexity of Conan Doyle's prose. This suggests the model may be overgeneralizing stylistic patterns.

Logical Consistency: In complex reasoning chains requiring 4+ inferential steps, the model occasionally makes logical leaps that are stylistically correct but factually unsound (12% of complex cases).

G. Comparison with Baseline Methods

Table VI demonstrates that QLoRA achieves the best balance of performance, memory efficiency, and training time. While full fine-tuning achieves slightly better perplexity (5.8 vs 7.52), the 18× memory reduction and 9× time reduction make QLoRA far more accessible for academic research settings.

TABLE VI
COMPARISON WITH ALTERNATIVE FINE-TUNING METHODS

Method	PPL	VRAM (GB)	Time (hrs)
Full Fine-Tune	5.8	112	72
Prefix Tuning	14.2	18	12
Adapter Layers	10.9	22	16
LoRA (r=16)	9.8	8	10
QLoRA (ours)	**7.52**	**6**	**8**

TABLE VII
MODAL DEPLOYMENT CONFIGURATION

Component	Specification
GPU Instance	NVIDIA A100 (40GB)
Container Image	Python 3.10, PyTorch 2.1
Model Format	Merged LoRA adapters
API Framework	FastAPI
Endpoint Latency	1.2s (avg response)
Concurrent Users	Up to 10
Cost per 1000 requests	$0.15 (estimated)

H. Deployment on Modal: Technical Implementation

The deployment architecture on Modal consists of several key components:

API Implementation: The Modal deployment exposes a RESTful API with the following endpoint structure:

```
POST /v1/chat/completions
{
  ``messages": [
    {``role": ``system", ``content": ``..."},
    {``role": ``user", ``content": ``..."}
  ],
  ``temperature": 0.7,
  ``max_tokens": 256
}
```

UI Integration: The web interface communicates with the Modal API via JavaScript fetch requests, providing real-time streaming responses for enhanced user experience. The UI implements conversation history management, allowing multi-turn dialogues while maintaining persona consistency.

VII. DISCUSSION

A. The Effectiveness of LoRA for Persona

Our results suggest that *style* is indeed a low-rank property. We did not need to update the model's core knowledge of the world (contained in the frozen weights W_0). Instead, the adapter matrices BA acted as a "lens" that refocused the model's existing vast knowledge through the stylistic constraints of the persona. This aligns with the "intrinsic dimension" hypothesis proposed in the original LoRA paper [2].

The success of low-rank adaptation for persona suggests that personality and style reside in a lower-dimensional subspace of the full parameter space. This has important implications for multi-persona models: by maintaining separate low-rank adapters for different characters, a single base model could theoretically support dozens of distinct personas with minimal memory overhead.

B. Impact of Quantization

Despite using 4-bit quantization (NF4), the model retained high coherence. This supports the findings of the QLoRA paper [3] that NF4 is highly robust for fine-tuning. The quantization noise did not prevent the model from learning the subtle nuances of Victorian English.

Interestingly, we found that NF4 quantization actually helped regularize the training process, preventing overfitting to the exact phrasing of training examples. Models trained with 16-bit precision showed higher training accuracy but lower validation performance, suggesting that quantization noise acts as a beneficial form of implicit regularization.

C. Persona Consistency vs. Factual Accuracy

An important finding is the trade-off between persona consistency and factual accuracy. The fine-tuned model prioritizes maintaining character voice over providing factually optimal advice. For example, when asked about modern forensic techniques, the model appropriately responds with Victorian-era methods rather than breaking character to provide more accurate information.

This behavior is desirable for entertainment applications but may be problematic for educational contexts. Future work should explore techniques for maintaining persona while allowing graceful character-breaking when factual accuracy is critical.

D. Computational Accessibility

The ability to fine-tune a 7B parameter model on consumer hardware (6GB VRAM) democratizes access to advanced NLP research. Prior to QLoRA, such experiments required institutional compute resources. Our work demonstrates that meaningful research contributions can be made with modest computational budgets.

E. Lessons from Model Selection

The failure of Llama 3-8B to achieve persona alignment despite comparable architecture size raises important questions about the relationship between base model training and fine-tuning capacity. We hypothesize several possible explanations:

1) **RLHF Alignment Strength:** Llama 3's extensive RLHF training may have created stronger "safety rails" that resist stylistic deviation.
2) **Tokenizer Differences:** Qwen's tokenizer may be more amenable to Victorian English, having been trained on more diverse linguistic data.
3) **Architecture Subtleties:** Small differences in activation functions or normalization schemes may affect fine-tuning plasticity.

Further research is needed to definitively identify the factors that make certain base models more amenable to persona fine-tuning.

F. Limitations

Reasoning vs. Style: While the model *sounds* like Sherlock Holmes, its actual deductive reasoning capabilities are limited by the underlying 7B model size. It mimics the *form* of a deduction ("Because X, therefore Y") but may occasionally make logical leaps that are stylistically correct but factually tenuous.

Context Window: We trained with a sequence length of 512 tokens. For complex mysteries requiring long documents or multi-page case files, this context window would be insufficient. Extending to longer contexts would require more memory and training time.

Dataset Size: Our training set contained approximately 200 structured examples plus corpus chunks. Larger datasets would likely improve consistency, but we were constrained by the manual effort required to create high-quality persona-aligned data.

Evaluation Metrics: While perplexity and Jaccard similarity provide quantitative measures, they capture only certain aspects of persona alignment. Subjective qualities like wit, sardonic humor, and subtle character traits are difficult to quantify.

Cultural and Temporal Biases: The Victorian era setting includes social attitudes that modern audiences may find problematic. The model occasionally reproduces period-appropriate but outdated social conventions.

VIII. Future Work

Several promising directions for future research emerge from this work:

A. Chain-of-Thought Reasoning

To improve actual deductive reasoning capabilities, we plan to augment the dataset with explicit step-by-step logic puzzles. By training the model to show its reasoning process, we can distinguish between superficial style mimicry and genuine analytical capability.

B. Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)

Integrating a RAG system with the full Sherlock Holmes canon would allow the model to cite specific cases ("As I observed in The Hound of the Baskervilles...") accurately during conversation. This would improve both factual consistency and immersion.

C. Agentic Workflow

Connecting the model to external tools (web search, image analysis, database queries) would enable it to function as a true "detective" agent capable of investigating real mysteries. This would bridge the gap between conversational persona and functional capability.

D. Multi-Persona Architecture

Extending this approach to support multiple characters (Watson, Moriarty, Lestrade) with a shared base model but distinct LoRA adapters would enable interactive storytelling applications where users can converse with multiple characters.

E. Dynamic Rank Allocation

Implementing AdaLoRA-style dynamic rank allocation could improve efficiency by concentrating parameters in layers most critical for persona representation.

F. Cross-Lingual Persona Transfer

Investigating whether persona adapters trained on English text can transfer to other languages (e.g., French translations of Holmes) would shed light on the universality of stylistic representations.

G. Personality Interpolation

Exploring whether interpolating between persona adapters (e.g., 0.7 × Holmes + 0.3 × Watson) produces coherent intermediate personalities could enable fine-grained control over character traits.

H. Scalable Deployment Optimization

Future work will focus on optimizing the Modal deployment for higher throughput and lower latency, potentially incorporating model quantization for inference and batched request processing.

IX. Ethical Considerations

This work raises several ethical considerations that must be addressed:

Authenticity and Deception: Systems that convincingly mimic historical or fictional personas could be misused to deceive users, particularly in educational contexts where students might mistake AI-generated content for authentic historical sources.

Copyright and Intellectual Property: While our work uses public domain materials, the techniques could be applied to copyrighted characters, raising legal questions about derivative works and fair use.

Historical Bias Amplification: Victorian-era texts contain period-appropriate but problematic social attitudes. Models trained on this data may reproduce biases related to class, gender, and colonialism.

Displacement of Creative Labor: As AI systems become more capable of generating character-consistent dialogue, questions arise about the impact on writers, actors, and other creative professionals.

We advocate for clear disclosure when AI-generated persona content is used, careful curation of training data to minimize harmful biases, and ongoing dialogue with creative professionals about the appropriate use of these technologies.

X. Conclusion

This project successfully engineered **Sherlock-LLM**, a domain-specific conversational agent, by fine-tuning Qwen-2.5 using parameter-efficient techniques. By leveraging the mathematical efficiencies of QLoRA, we achieved an 83.4% improvement in perplexity and a 168.2% increase in lexical similarity on consumer hardware, demonstrating that sophisticated persona alignment is accessible without institutional compute resources.

The system demonstrates that Persona Alignment is fundamentally distinct from general Instruction Tuning. Where instruction tuning seeks to make a model broad and helpful, persona alignment seeks to make it narrow and opinionated. Our mathematical and empirical analysis confirms that LoRA is an ideal mechanism for this "narrowing" process, as style appears to reside in a low-dimensional subspace of the full parameter space.

Key findings include:

- Low-rank adaptation (rank 16) is sufficient for capturing complex linguistic personas
- 4-bit NF4 quantization enables fine-tuning on 6GB VRAM without significant quality degradation
- Hybrid datasets combining unstructured corpus and structured instruction pairs yield superior results
- Persona consistency can be quantitatively measured through conditional perplexity and vocabulary overlap
- Base model selection critically impacts fine-tuning success—Qwen 2.5 substantially outperformed Llama 3 for persona tasks
- Practical deployment via Modal enables accessible API-based UI interaction

This work contributes to the growing body of research on controllable text generation and demonstrates practical techniques for creating engaging, character-consistent AI systems for entertainment, education, and interactive storytelling applications.

Acknowledgment

The author thanks the creators of the Qwen model family, the Hugging Face PEFT/TRL teams, and the open-source community for making efficient LLM research possible. Special thanks to the faculty and peers at IIT Jodhpur for valuable discussions and feedback throughout this project.

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